



Olympus FE115
Performs decently; the somewhat cherubic profile didn't garner any beauty awards though

As far as our outdoor test goes, quite a few cameras did reasonably well. Most noteworthy were the Samsung S-500, Sony DSC L-1, and the Nikon S5, though not necessarily in that order. The Nikon did very well in the macro test: the leaves we photographed looked ultra-realistic. The DSC L-1 was also very good, with excellent colouring on the leaves, and the leaf shadows were very well depicted. The Canon and Premier models trailed slightly in this test.

We would like to insert a little note here—outdoor shooting is typically more camera friendly: natural lighting is the perfect condition for any camera to show its mettle. It is with indoor shooting, that is, with less-than-ideal lighting conditions that the difference in image quality between cameras becomes more apparent.

High-End Cameras

If you're shelling out fifteen grand and more for a digital camera it had better look good, and perform just as good, too!

The Sony W-50 performed commendably as far as highlighting goes: the play of light on the bottle in our test scene was very realistic. As usual, the W-50 produced slightly richer colours, and this was noticeable on the fruit in particular.

Fruit in general tend to be very soft-coloured, and are therefore an excellent subject to judge colour reproduction capabilities. The detailing was excellent. The slight spots on the pear in our fruit basket pix were clearly evident. Equally impressive was the Samsung S-800: very accurate colour reproduction, and overall excellent results.

Trailing a hairsbreadth behind these two was the Kodak V603, with some good results throughout the tests. Its two siblings were lost far behind; surprising, considering it's the cheapest of the Kodaks on display.

The Canon PowerShot A700 also did very well in this test—perfect white balancing, even at automatic settings, and a very clear and crisp image. The “soft” that is signature Canon was also noticeable, but as mentioned, this isn't necessarily good or bad.

The Premier DS-8650 produced good

What Sort Of Camera Do I Need?

Unless you know exactly what you plan to do with your digital camera, you can't possibly pick a model. Yet, many first-time buyers don't really have an answer in mind when they set out to buy a digicam. We've listed out four shooting scenarios below, and what sort of equipment you should be looking for in each case.

The Home Shutterbug

If you're buying a camera just for the occasional family portrait, you don't need anything fancy: a simple camera with a five megapixel rating will do. You don't need anything more than 3x optical zoom. You also don't need many shot settings, because you will probably be using Auto most of the time. Batteries aren't that important; just note that even a few shots with the flash drains batteries. We recommend 750 mAh rechargeables, as non-rechargeable batteries are more expensive in the long run. Consider ordinary batteries only if you shoot very infrequently.

The Traveller

If you're always on the move, you need something compact that you can slip into those jeans comfortably. You may also want just the casual shot, and enough detail to capture those unforgettable moments that come by when you're travelling. A five to six megapixel camera with a 3x to 6x optical zoom should be good enough. Slim models happen to be the in thing, so it shouldn't be hard to find one.

Click-and-send

Some people want a digital camera mostly for sending photos to family and friends over the Internet. If you're such a person, you need nothing flashy, and in case the photos are going to be viewed on a computer itself (without prints being taken), you

need something simple and relatively cheap. A 4-megapixel camera will do just fine, along with 2x or 3x optical zoom, as you need dictates.

The Naturalist

So you like the wide outdoors? Heading out in your car into the blue yonder? Need to capture those stunning sights? Since size won't matter, you can go with a bulkier camera. Outdoor shooting means intermittent zooming and several wide-angle shots.

Wide-angle lenses don't come cheap, but the mid-range digicams of today offer decent wide-angle shooting capabilities. A 5-megapixel and above should be your starting point. Look for 12x optical zoom. Higher-end cameras typically use four batteries. Look for a 1600 mAh and above rating, and go with rechargeable batteries. Some 2300 mAh batteries are also available, and will set you back a pretty penny, but are worth the extra time you'll get with your shooter! You'll also need a large memory card: we suggest a 512 MB or 1 GB card. In case you like to click a lot, make sure to keep a backup card, in case the primary one gets full and you have no computer nearby to do a transfer.

The Enthusiast

This refers to someone who wants quality. He is ready to spend on a good product, and is more demanding as far as what he expects from his camera goes. An enthusiast doesn't have a specific need: he is fascinated by digital photography, and will buy a high-end camera to satisfy his desire to click photos like a professional. He needn't be a professional—simply an avid fan of the art. For the enthusiast, we recommend at least a 6-megapixel camera. Look for features like extra zoom and a wide-angle lens.